How Bureaucracies Acquire Information from a Partisan Media Supply

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Abstract

How do bureaucracies seek information? Bureaucrats rely on news media to navigate a complex information environment and make strategic decisions, yet the volume of news is overwhelming. Agencies, therefore, contract private firms to distill news into daily "briefings." Drawing from government contracts, I describe how and why these briefings are produced. I then analyze briefings across U.S. executive agencies and find a systematic skew. Conservative news sources appear more often in briefings for conservative agencies like Immigration and Customs Enforcement. I explore whether this skew reflects biased news selection or differences in underlying news supply. I show that, across agencies, news supply can explain the relationship between agency ideology and news slant. However, during Trump's second term, briefings shift in ways supply cannot explain. These findings reveal previously unidentified disparities in the bureaucratic information supply while recognizing that biased selection can arise under some conditions that warrant further investigation.

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1. Introduction

Effective government depends on bureaucrats acquiring accurate and timely political information. Incomplete or biased information can distort how bureaucrats perceive their strategic environment, affecting judgments about other political actors, public opinion, and policy (Patty, 2009). At the same time, despite the central role of expertise and information asymmetries in contemporary theories of American bureaucracy (Bawn, 1995; Gailmard & Patty, 2012b, 2012a; Patty, 2009), we know surprisingly little about how bureaucrats actually acquire information and develop expertise. In this paper, I examine how bureaucracies collect information from news media and investigate whether that collection is systematically skewed.

Across more than 2,000 agency daily news briefings, I find that briefings for liberal agencies contain strikingly little coverage from conservative media. By comparing the articles in these briefings to the supply of news about each agency, I find little evidence that agencies disproportionately select left- or right-leaning articles. This pattern is consistent with bureaucratic incentives since satisfying diverse internal constituencies generally encourages broad and comprehensive information collection. Instead, partisan imbalance lies upstream in the supply of news about agencies. Across agencies and time periods, conservative outlets produce less coverage of liberal agencies, and liberal outlets similarly under-cover conservative agencies.

While unbiased selection is typically viewed as normatively desirable, it may not be the optimal collection strategy, especially when the underlying supply of news is skewed. Even absent preferential selection, agency information environments can be systematically distorted. The very system designed to ensure that officials are well-informed can itself filter, distort, or politicize information. These processes matter. The information that reaches federal decision makers determines which actors, issues, and narratives are most visible and shapes beliefs about the larger strategic environment. Even when selection is unbiased, the final product can still provide a partial and incomplete picture of public opinion and the

larger political environment.

Although the supply-side asymmetry is evident across a broad set of agencies and time periods and is large enough to explain the disparity in the briefings, these aggregate findings do not rule out preferential selection under certain conditions. I find some evidence that changes in agency leadership can affect partisan news collection. Consistent with the second Trump administration's hostility towards mainstream news media, the composition of Homeland Security briefings dramatically changed after Donald Trump returned to office in 2025. However, changes in agency leadership does not always lead to changes in briefing composition. After Trump's first inauguration in 2017, the composition of the Department of the Interior's briefings remained relatively stable. Although not conclusive, these findings suggest that individuals involved in news collection may, under certain conditions, shape the partisan content of the briefings.

In summary, agency news collection is shaped by the interaction between media monitoring tools and the news supply. Among articles that mention agencies by name, I find no evidence of systematic preferential selection from ideologically aligned news sources. In contrast, I find that partisan asymmetries in the supply of news about agencies are closely reflected in the composition of the news briefings. While the supply-side pattern is highly robust across specifications, the aggregate results cannot rule out preferential selection under particular conditions.

This paper contributes to the growing literature on news media and political elites (see Green-Pedersen & Stubager, 2010; Karpowitz, 2009; Sevenans, 2017a; Severin-Nielsen et al., 2025; Vliegenthart, Walgrave, Wouters, et al., 2016; Vliegenthart, Walgrave, Baumgartner, et al., 2016; Willis, 2013). I add to this research by revealing that political elites have strong reasons to systematically monitor the news, even absent electoral incentives. More broadly, the findings speak to fundamental questions about political accountability, media effects, and information inequality. Unless we study how elites collect and use news, we will underestimate the role of media in political outcomes. This paper also speaks to recent work on

how partisan incentives, strategic gatekeeping and organizational structure shape information provision to institutions (Ban et al., 2023; Hirsch et al., 2023; You et al., 2024) and when executives exercise more control over bureaucrats (Bolton, 2022; Bolton & Thrower, 2016, 2022).

By leveraging a new source of data—administrative records of agency news briefings—this paper provides the first systematic evidence of how bureaucracies monitor the news. Combining qualitative analysis of media monitoring practices with quantitative analysis of briefing content reveals important disparities in the supply of news that have previously gone unrecognized.

2. Background

News contains valuable information, but bureaucrats have limited time to search for and consume it (Baumgartner & Jones, 2015). This problem has been intensified by the rise of the internet and media fragmentation (Bawden & Robinson, 2009). To solve this trade-off, U.S. agencies and other elite actors optimize information collection by creating daily news compilations—typically called daily news briefings, summaries, or "clipbooks." The content of these briefings depends on two key factors: (1) an agency's motives for media monitoring and (2) the underlying supply of news.

2.1. What are daily news briefings?

Like many political elites, federal agencies collect and distribute news. The tools used for media monitoring vary depending on the needs and resources of the user, but all of them involve searching a range of sources for news about specific topics of interest (National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration, 2020; Sullivan, 2012; Willis, 2013). Once relevant clips are identified, they are typically organized by story or topic with the most important stories appearing first (Sullivan, 2012).

To better understand the purpose of agency daily news summaries, I submitted Freedom of Information Act Requests (FOIAs) for internal emails, documents, and contracts related to custom daily media monitoring reports. I also reviewed contracts for media monitoring posted on USAspending.gov, examined solicitations for contracts on sam.gov, and searched through online archives where journalists and organizations post FOIA documents.

Today, most large agencies employ third-party vendors to compile an electronic daily news briefing or clipbook that is emailed every morning to a large number of staff (Sullivan, 2012, p. 20). Between 2002 and 2024, at least 26 agencies had contracts for custom media monitoring.[1] While government employees consume news outside of clipbooks and briefings, these documents are circulated widely and are consistently produced across a wide set of agencies and time periods. This consistency and ubiquity allow for comparison of government news collection across time and agencies.

The market for custom news reports is dominated by four companies: Bulletin Intelligence/Cision,[2] Barbaricum, TechMIS, and Rendon. Bulletin Intelligence's early employees were former members of the Reagan White House who had produced Reagan's news summaries (Bulletin News Network, 2001). Based on their websites and other government contracts, Barbaricum, TechMIS, and Rendon are veteran-owned businesses with large military contracts. While Bulletin dominated the market in the 2000s, it began losing contracts to Barbaricum, TechMIS, and Rendon in the mid-2010s. Today, all four companies hold lucrative contracts for agency news briefings.

According to the contracts, news briefings are generally targeted at agency leadership and communications staff. However, the email list often extends beyond these two audiences to include legislative affairs, intergovernmental affairs, budget offices, and other agency components. The list of email recipients depends on the agency, but based on internal emails and the contracts, briefings are often sent to thousands of employees. For example, the Department of Homeland Security (2023) contract documents reported approximately 5,000

[1]The replication files include a list of agency media monitoring contracts.

[2]Bulletin Intelligence was acquired by Cision, Inc. in 2017 (Bulletin Intelligence, 2025).

recipients in 2023. In its 2014 contract, the Nuclear Regulatory Commission (2014) required agency-wide circulation. In 2017, one contractor, TechMIS, reported serving over 50,000 government employees (Mains, 2017, p. 5).

In addition to staff who directly receive the full agency news briefing, some individual departments or offices forward a smaller set of relevant clips to their staff. Employees also forward the news clips as a way of starting policy-relevant conversations. For example, in an email chain from May 2017, DOI employees discuss how to respond to a local news story about coyote hunting (Foley et al., 2017). In another example from the VA, an employee suggests that an article in the news briefing be sent to the Commissioners prior to an upcoming meeting (Leinenkugel, 2018).

Agency news briefings are the product of a multi-step process and tailored to the priorities and goals of each agency. First, the contractor and agency decide on a procedure for identifying potentially relevant articles. Usually, this involves selecting which news sources to monitor[3] and identifying a set of topics or keywords. These keywords are used to identify a set of potentially relevant articles. Next, the contractor applies human judgment and an expert understanding of the agency to sort articles into the appropriate section of the briefing, remove irrelevant or redundant information, and produce a short 1-3 sentence summary of each article. Each article citation is accompanied by basic metadata about the article, including a link to the full text or video, the authors, and the publication date. Typically, the articles are then aggregated by 'story.' For each story, only one to four article summaries are provided. If a story is picked up by many news organizations, additional articles are linked at the bottom of the story but not separately summarized.

In summary, the content of agency news briefings reflects both the underlying supply of news and a series of choices made by agencies and their contractors. These choices depend on an agency's motives for collecting news.

[3]Contractors report monitoring over 50,500 traditional news sources and 400,000 social media accounts and blogs (Mains, 2017, p. 5).

2.2. Why do agencies collect news?

While there is a substantial literature on the importance of information and specialization in U.S. bureaucracies (e.g. Gailmard & Patty, 2012a; Workman, 2015), we know surprisingly little about how bureaucrats collect information. Given the rich information content of news, it should not be surprising that bureaucrats invest in news collection. Like many political elites, bureaucrats face critical strategic decisions where success or failure depends on their expectations about other political actors. News contains a wealth of information about the activities and positions of these actors (Cook, 1998). Many agencies also rely on news to monitor the effectiveness of their own communication efforts as well as to gather other policy-relevant information (Baumgartner & Jones, 2015; Bustos, 2021; D. Carpenter, 2014; D. P. Carpenter & Krause, 2012). As a result, they have fundamentally different incentives for consuming news media, relative to the general public. In general, agencies are incentivized to collect a broad selection of media.

For bureaucrats, the value of news is not necessarily tied to perceptions of trustworthiness or factual accuracy. Whereas members of the public tend to seek out news they regard as credible and that aligns with their partisan or ideological leanings (e.g. Guess, 2021; Iyengar & Hahn, 2009; Mangold et al., 2024), bureaucrats generally need to monitor their political adversaries and correct false narratives, leading them to value news from low-quality or untrustworthy sources (Kornfield et al., 2025). Because the content of news and the politicians featured in news vary by partisan slant (Kim et al., 2022), we would expect bureaucrats and the agencies they represent to seek out news from a diverse and comprehensive set of sources.

While an agency's optimal strategy for news collection will depend on a multitude of factors, their motives for collecting news will generally disincentivize biased selection of ideologically-aligned news sources. Media monitoring contracts and other internal agency records point to three primary motives underlying news collection: (1) monitoring the strategic environment, (2) evaluating agency communications, and (3) gathering policy feedback.

Additionally, although not explicitly described in the contracts, prior research suggests another motive: developing and maintaining policy expertise.

First, agencies use news to monitor their strategic environment. While information may be available through other channels, media coverage is often the most straightforward and efficient means of finding out what is going on in politics (Cook, 1998). It is not a coincidence that news collection has been a critical part of open source intelligence collection for over a century (Van Puyvelde & Rienzi, 2023). Even censored or 'fake news' contains information relevant to predicting other actors' future actions.

In addition to monitoring external actors, agency leaders use news to monitor their own agencies and reduce agency loss through "reality testing" (Burke & Greenstein, 1989; Karpowitz, 2009).[4] All media monitoring contracts require that briefings contain coverage of the agency, and most specify that the briefings will be used to keep officials broadly informed. The Department of the Interior (2021) contract specifies why a broad focus is necessary: "so they can interact with peers in the administration and congress" (p. 2). Often, agency briefings have dedicated sections for national news or sections for news about other institutions like Congress, the White House, or the Supreme Court (see, for example, Department of Justice, 2012; Department of the Interior, 2021).

Second, media contains information critical to evaluating an agency's communications and public relations efforts. An agency's reputation is a vital strategic asset that can be used to manage internal and external threats (Bustos, 2021; D. P. Carpenter & Krause, 2012). Almost every contract connects news monitoring to communications or public relations, and many specify that they are interested in monitoring "public interest" in the agency or a "larger public conversation" (see, for example, Drug Enforcement Administration, 2019; Environmental Protection Agency, 2016; Nuclear Regulatory Commission, 2014; Small Business Administration, 2022). For bureaucrats with limited direct feedback mechanisms, media coverage can serve as an important indicator of public sentiment. Surveys of

[4]See also the literature on censorship and authoritarian regimes (Distelhorst, 2013; Lorentzen, 2014) and the literature on "stovepiping" (Gailmard & Patty, 2013).

bureaucrats have found that career civil servants are attentive to media portrayals of their agency's work (Karlsen et al., 2020).

In addition to protecting their reputations, agencies with strong communications capacities are better positioned to advance policy goals and core missions (see Cook, 1998, pp. 148–149). This is evident in contracts from both public-facing agencies like the Department of Veterans Affairs and those that primarily interact with other institutions, such as the Drug Enforcement Administration. The Department of Veterans Affairs (2013) contract explains that communication is critical to informing veterans and their families about available benefits and programs. The Drug Enforcement Administration (2019) promotes its mission by raising public awareness about U.S. drug laws and their consequences. The link between communication and policy provision is especially strong during emergencies (Bonnevie et al., 2021; Environmental Protection Agency, 2016; Miller & Goidel, 2009; Prue et al., 2003; Small Business Administration, 2022).

Third, news can provide policy feedback by alerting agencies to emerging problems. In their contracts, agencies describe using media monitoring as a form of "fire alarm" oversight (McCubbins & Schwartz, 1984). The Consumer Product Safety Commission (2020) contract explains that news clips support "[e]merging hazards identification, remedial strategy analysis, and regulatory development" and have brought serious product-related accidents to the Commission's attention (p. 4-14). Similarly, the Department of Labor (2020) notes that news clips alert staff to emerging issues and provide leads for investigations. The value of media as a feedback mechanism is also evident in research on authoritarian regimes, where governments may limit censorship to preserve access to useful information (Distelhorst, 2013; King et al., 2013; Lorentzen, 2014). More broadly, media coverage can shape policy by influencing which problems governments detect and define (Baumgartner & Jones, 2015).

Policy-relevant information can also contribute to bureaucratic expertise. Prior research emphasizes that bureaucratic expertise is developed over time as bureaucrats invest in acquiring policy-relevant information (Bawn, 1995; Gailmard & Patty, 2007, 2012b). Monitoring

news can help bureaucrats stay informed about developments in their policy area.

Together, these motives will generally push agencies to search widely for relevant news, collecting articles from a wide range of sources and perspectives. While an individual bureaucrat may disproportionately value a particular type of information, agency news briefings are designed to satisfy multiple audiences and purposes within the agency. The relative importance of these motives may shift an agency's optimal monitoring strategy, but systematically favoring ideologically-aligned sources is unlikely to satisfy all of the constituencies within an agency.

While the agency as a whole might benefit from a broad approach to news selection, it is possible for the briefings to be influenced by the interests of individuals within the agency. The contracts and internal emails suggest that the final composition of the briefings is a result of an incremental process where some individuals and groups have greater input. Contractors learn what to include in the news summaries by talking with agency staff and getting continuous feedback from various individuals at the agency (see Joshua, 2018). Research on the mass public shows that people tend to prefer news sources aligned with their partisan leanings (Guess, 2021), raising the possibility that similar preferences among agency staff could shape the briefings' content. Moreover, even unbiased information-gathering staff may optimally skew information collection toward the priorities of a sufficiently biased political principal (Patty, 2009). Thus, the preferences of influential agency leaders could shape information collection even when the individuals collecting the news do not share those preferences.

Under some circumstances, agency leaders may also take steps to intentionally alter the information available to their staff. Two incidents during the first Trump administration suggest that other considerations can dominate the needs of some constituencies within an agency. In the first case, Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) leadership prioritized controlling the flow of information within the agency over maximizing the value of the news briefing to the EPA as a whole. In 2017, EPA leadership first pressured and then fired

Bulletin Intelligence during a dispute about negative coverage of EPA leadership in the daily news briefing (Ericksen, 2017b).

In the second case, the Department of Justice (DOJ) fired its contractor after employees complained to reporters about "a blog post from a white nationalist website [VDare] that used an anti-Semitic slur" (Barrett, 2019). Arguably, some parts of the agency might benefit from following a white nationalist news source. Benkler et al. (2018) document that more popular far-right sources like Breitbart pick up stories from VDare and circulate them to a wider audience (p. 124). Monitoring VDare would alert the DOJ to potentially damaging or inflammatory stories before they are picked up by other parts of the conservative media ecosystem. However, the value of the news was not large enough to outweigh the costs imposed on other employees and the risk of additional negative news coverage (see also Aleaziz et al., 2019).

While the motives were different, both the EPA and DOJ narrowed the scope of their news briefings to control what stories circulated. These examples also emphasize that contractors are separate actors in the news collection process. Although agencies establish collection priorities and provide feedback, contractors exercise judgment in implementing those instructions. The EPA case shows how their choices may not always align with agency preferences, and the DOJ case suggests that contractors are incentivized to proactively avoid outlets that are objectionable to their audience. At the same time, both cases also demonstrate the agency's ultimate power over contractors. While recognizing the role of contractor discretion, I nonetheless expect the briefings to generally reflect agency preferences.

In summary, news collection within agencies is the product of multiple motives and goals. The final product will depend on the supply of relevant news and key decisions during the news selection process. As a whole, agencies should actively seek out news from all partisan or ideological perspectives. However, when we consider the agencies as collections of individuals with their own biases and incentives, there are scenarios where individual biases or motives could affect news selection.

3. Methods

Previous attempts to study elite news consumption relied on interviews and surveys (Kingdon, 1992; Sevenans et al., 2016; Sevenans, 2017a, 2017b). However, surveys and interviews may underestimate the role of news (Kingdon, 1992, pp. 59–60). Elite recollection of media consumption may be inadequate when they regularly review large volumes of information from numerous sources. In such contexts, self-reports may fail to capture the scope and nature of news exposure. While internal government records have limitations, they offer a detailed and verifiable foundation for studying elite communication.

To examine the balance of partisan news in agency news briefings, I first categorize the sources cited in agency news briefings. To assess whether the ideological biases of agency staff affect the selection of news, I compare news collection across liberal and conservative agencies and across Democratic and Republican presidential administrations. I also compare the agency news briefings to the news supply.

3.1. Daily News Briefs

I collected custom news briefings produced for U.S. executive agencies by private contractors. Using USAspending, the U.S. government's official database of federal spending information, I identified custom media monitoring contracts for 26 federal agencies. On average, each contract is worth approximately $200,000 per year. I use contractor-produced reports because FOIA requests and database search queries need to be specific. Unlike internally-produced reports, third-party contractors use consistent and distinct naming conventions across their reports.

After identifying contractors, I searched publicly-available databases and submitted FOIAs for briefings produced by the contractors. I selected four sets of briefings where I had more than 30 copies of briefings from multiple presidential administrations. Collectively, these briefings were produced for four agencies by three different third-party contractors

under four presidential administrations.

Department of Homeland Security (DHS) and **U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS)** – The Department of Homeland Security (DHS) is responsible for policy areas and agencies related to immigration, security, and terrorism. The U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS) is a sub-agency of DHS tasked with administering the U.S. naturalization and immigration system. Webpages for TechMIS-produced USCIS and DHS news briefings are indexed and can be found through a search engine like Google. Although USCIS is a subagency of DHS, the briefings are separate. USCIS and DHS have separate contracts with TechMIS. In total, I collected all USCIS briefings from February 1, 2022 through November 5, 2025 (n=922) and all DHS briefings from January 2, 2024 through November 5, 2025 (n=655).[5] In both briefings, the citations contained hyperlinks. I identified sources by extracting the URLs and hyperlink text. A small number of cited articles were excluded from the analysis because they did not have URLs or identifiable names.

Department of Veterans Affairs (VA) – The Department of Veterans Affairs (VA) provides healthcare and benefits for U.S. military veterans and their families. Barbaricum-produced VA daily news briefings from June 3, 2020 through February 25, 2021 are available through the VA History Office's Covid-19 archive ($n = 233$). The archive contains all VA briefings from June 3, 2020 through January 2021. Some of the February 2021 briefings are missing from the archive. Like the DHS and USCIS briefings, I extracted hyperlinked URLs to identify cited articles.

Department of the Interior (DOI) – The U.S. Department of the Interior (DOI) is responsible for numerous policy areas relating to national parks, wildlife, Native Americans, energy, and U.S. territories. Unlike the other agencies, the DOI sample is not complete. To identify DOI briefings, I searched an online archive where journalists and interest groups post FOIA-produced documents. In total, I discovered 216 copies of DOI daily news briefings

[5]USCIS briefings are only produced for weekdays (Monday-Friday). DHS briefings are produced for all days of the week, excluding federal holidays.

produced by Bulletin Intelligence between February 19, 2015 and November 13, 2018 and 7 briefings produced by Barbaricum from February to May 2019 (n=223). Because the DOI briefing sample depends on journalist and interest group FOIAs, I only have briefings that mention certain keywords. While this could introduce bias, it is unlikely that sampling bias explains the results (for details, see Appendix A.1.1).

Because the hyperlinks were stripped from the PDFs, identifying the DOI sources required a different process. To convert the DOI briefings into structured data, I used the Gemini 2.0 Flash large language model (LLM) to identify all news sources in the briefings and extract the original text for each source, including any typos (for details, see Appendix A.1). I manually reviewed the output and removed misidentified sources. I then split the documents by heading and searched each section for the source text snippets. To categorize each source and add source domains, I cleaned the text snippets, merged them with names of U.S. news sources from ABYZ News Links, and filled in missing information based on my own review of the news source.

3.2. Categorizing Sources

To evaluate the balance of agency news diets, I categorized sources by partisan slant, which is the degree to which a source's reporting generally reflects a particular political affiliation or ideological leaning. I only report the Media Bias/Fact Check (MBFC) scores in the main paper because they are the most complete and missingness is uncorrelated with agency ideology; however, I replicate the results using three other measures of partisan slant (see Appendix A.1 for details). Two of the sources—Media Bias/Fact Check (MBFC) and AllSides—use human coders to assign partisan slant scores and two of the sources— Bakshy et al. (2015) and Robertson et al. (2018)—estimate slant based on website audience. Regardless of the measure, the news briefings tend to contain more center or liberal-leaning news, although there is variation across agencies and briefings (see Figure A5).

When analyzing partisan bias, I excluded three types of sources: local general interest

news sources (25.7%), government websites (0.2%), and sources with no identifiable URLs or names (0.1%). Local general interest sources are defined by their geographic scope, prioritizing news and stories that directly impact the residents of the community they serve. News outlets that focus exclusively on local or state politics (e.g. the Oregon Capital Chronicle) are not considered general interest. General interest local sources were dropped because the MBFC scores were less complete and there was less agreement between the MBFC and AllSides scores for local general interest sources (see Table A1). In the Appendix, I show that the results are similar if local general interest sources and government websites are included. The results are also robust to including only general interest sources.

After excluding government and general interest local news, 5.3% of the articles in the briefings could not be matched to MBFC scores. Partisan bias is missing for less than 6% of the articles in the DOI, DHS, and USCIS briefings, but the VA briefing is missing scores for 29.3% of articles. The VA briefing has more missing scores because it contains more news from smaller, specialized news outlets.

3.3. Agencies

By exploiting the structure of the DOI and DHS news briefings, I estimate news collection for 16 separate agencies. Both the DHS and DOI are large cabinet agencies that oversee many smaller agencies, bureaus, and offices. Their briefings are broken into sections, and some of these sections are dedicated to specific subagencies (see Table 1). Table 1 summarizes each agency in the sample. Notably, subagency headings are not included in every briefing; the total dates column indicates how many briefings contain a section for the agency.

Estimates of DHS and DOI news collection use the whole briefing, including sections that do not correspond to a specific subagency (e.g. "top news"). Estimates for their subagencies use only the section of the briefing corresponding to the subagency. Because USCIS has its own dedicated section of the DHS news summary, the USCIS results are estimated twice. The first estimate is based on the separate USCIS news briefing. The second is based on the

USCIS section of the DHS news briefing. The USCIS results suggest that the composition of a subagency's briefing is reasonably similar to its section of the parent agency's briefing. This is consistent with agency emails, where subagency staff discuss their input into the briefings. For example, in a 2018 email, a DOI subagency employee encouraged others to also send Bulletin Intelligence "articles that are important to your mission and you think should be highlighted [in the main DOI briefing]" (Joshua, 2018).

To test whether agency ideology shapes news collection, I use agency ideology scores from Richardson et al. (2018), which characterize the long-term policy views of government agencies and range from -2 to 2. The sixteen agencies in my main analysis span a wide range (-1.59 to 1.79). The results replicate with alternative measures of agency ideology (Chen & Johnson, 2015; Clinton & Lewis, 2008; Napolio, 2025). I report Richardson et al. because two alternatives only have scores for five of the agencies, and Napolio (2025) uses an LLM trained on media coverage, raising concerns about reverse causality.

The agencies represented in the briefing data are not a probability sample. They disproportionately represent large cabinet departments and contain no independent agencies or EOP organizations (see A.1.4). Nevertheless, the sample includes both liberal and conservative organizations and cabinet components of varying size.

3.4. News Supply (Media Cloud)

As previously described, the composition of the briefings is determined by the supply of news and the news selection process. To estimate the supply of news, I queried Media Cloud, an open-source collection of online news, for articles from U.S. news sources that mention each agency name (Roberts et al., 2021). Because the coverage quality varies over time (see Appendix A.9), I do not use Media Cloud to compare news selection across presidential administrations. However, comparing across agencies reveals how news outlets allocate limited reporting resources during periods where data is available.

Table 1: Composition of briefing data. Article sample sizes and unique sources calculated after dropping local general interest sources and government websites. Date sample sizes based on entire sample.

Briefing	Agency	Agency Name	Part of Briefing	Years	Total Articles	Total Dates	Unique Sources
DOI	DOI	Department of Interior	Whole	2015-19	27,969	223	691
DOI	BLM	Bureau of Land Management	Section	2015-19	589	219	84
DOI	FWS	Fish and Wildlife Service	Section	2015-19	1,171	218	152
DOI	GS	US Geological Survey	Section	2015-19	408	163	94
DOI	NPS	National Park Service	Section	2015-19	1,602	218	164
DOI	BIA	Bureau of Indian Affairs	Section	2017-19	244	135	47
DOI	BOR	Bureau of Reclamation	Section	2017-19	98	110	39
VA	VA	Department of Veterans Affairs	Whole	2020-21	2,386	233	160
USCIS	USCIS	US Citizenship and Immigration Services	Whole	2022-25	26,773	922	455
DHS	DHS	Department of Homeland Security	Whole	2024-25	61,446	655	291
DHS	CG	Coast Guard	Section	2024-25	1,875	583	105
DHS	FEMA	Federal Emergency Management Agency	Section	2024-25	5,243	643	87
DHS	SS	Secret Service	Section	2024-25	1,980	567	124
DHS	TSA	Transportation Security Administration	Section	2024-25	1,128	454	57
DHS	USCBP	Customs and Border Protection	Section	2024-25	3,664	648	81
DHS	USCIS	US Citizenship and Immigration Services	Section	2024-25	2,459	591	77
DHS	USICE	Immigration and Customs Enforcement	Section	2024-25	6,414	618	89

After dropping local general interest sources and government sources, the Media Cloud database contains 478 of the 1,275 domains in the briefing dataset. However, these domains account for 94% of the articles in the briefings. For more details about the representativeness of the Media Cloud sample, see Appendix A.6.4. For more details about the queries, see Appendix A.6 and A.10. As a robustness check, I also replicated the analysis using the Global Database of Events, Language, and Tone (GDELT), which is another large collection of online news.

4. Results

The following analysis evaluates whether agency news collection is balanced and, if not, whether the imbalance reflects biased selection or supply. I first document a strong association between agency ideology and the partisan composition of news briefings. However, the same pattern appears in the supply of news about agencies, and I find no evidence of systematic preferential selection across briefings. I then show that the supply-side asymmetry

is not a product of the agencies and time periods in my sample. It appears in the supply of news about a larger set of agencies and time periods. Finally, I examine the limits of this explanation and explore how changes in news selection can occur under some conditions.

4.1. Partisan news collection across agencies

Is agency ideology associated with the partisan composition of news briefings?

To examine the relationship between the partisan content of the briefings and agency ideology, I calculate how often each briefing cites articles from left-leaning, center, or right-leaning news sources. In Figure 1, I drop articles from sources that could not be matched to partisan slant. The proportion of articles with missing partisan slant scores is generally low and unrelated to agency ideology (see Figure A5).

For each partisan slant category, I create a subplot comparing the proportion of articles in the category to agency ideology. Due to the structure of the U.S. media market, the results should be particularly clear when comparing agency ideology to the amount of news from right-leaning news sources (Benkler et al., 2018; Guess, 2021). The scarcity of major center-right outlets makes it easier to differentiate center and right-leaning sources (see Figure A2).

The results in Figure 1 show a strong association between agency ideology and the partisan composition of the briefings. Conservative agencies collect more news from right-leaning sources and less news from center and left-leaning news sources, relative to more liberal agencies. As expected, this pattern is most evident in the 'Right-leaning' subplot. The best fit line ($\beta = 0.062$) is substantively large: comparing the most liberal to the most conservative agency, we would expect a 24.8 percentage point increase in right-leaning coverage. For regression tables and alternative regression specifications, see Appendix A.2.

As previously discussed, the partisan composition of briefings in Figure 1 is the product of the available supply of news and the news selection process. Given strong motives for comprehensive news selection, I expect the disparity in Figure 1 to be produced by an

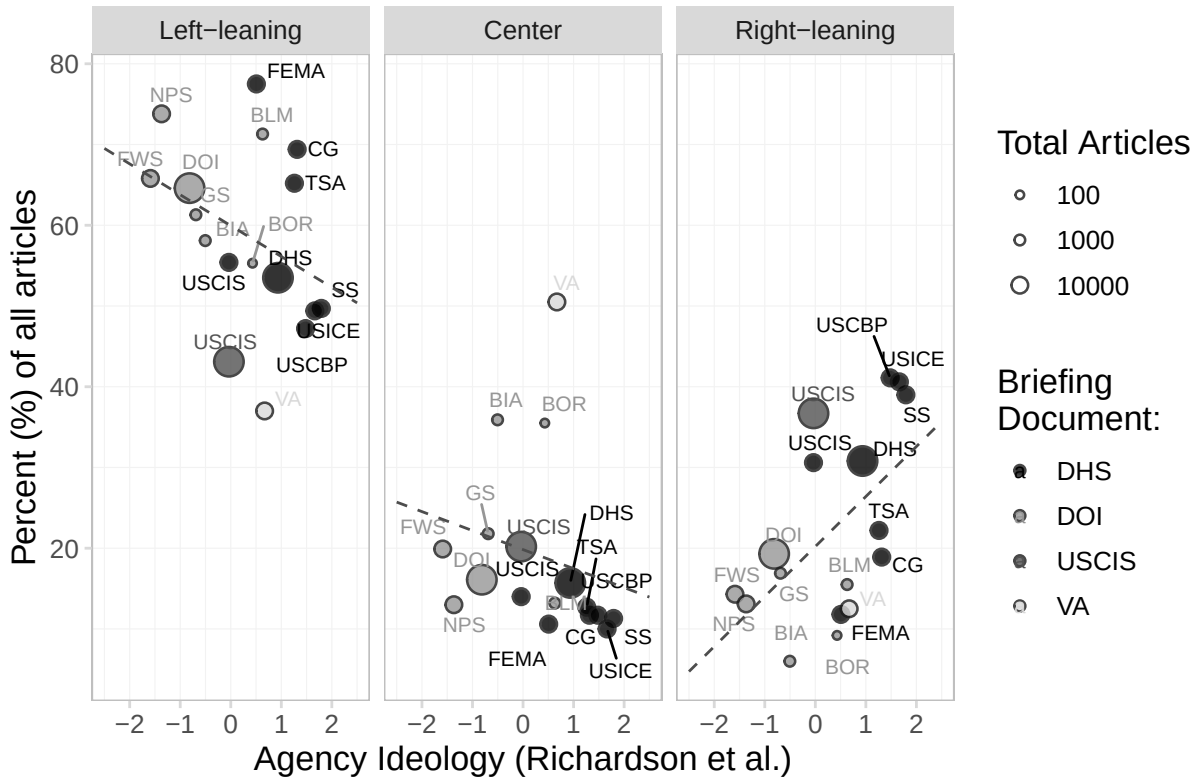


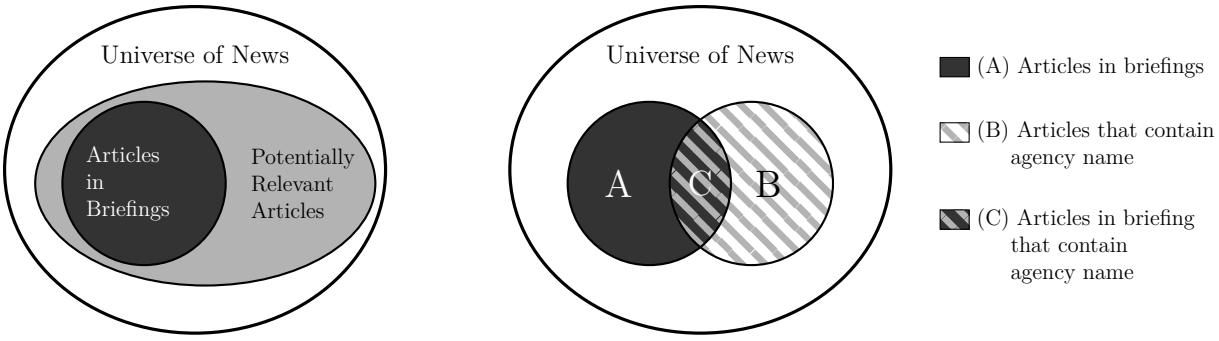
Figure 1: Association between agency ideology and the partisan-slant of sources in agency news briefings. The y-axis is the proportion of articles in a partisan-slant category (Center, Left-leaning, or Right-leaning). Partisan slant is determined by the source of an article.

asymmetric supply of news, rather than biased selection.

Is there an asymmetric supply of news?

Consistent with a supply-side explanation for the relationship in Figure 1, I find a sizable partisan asymmetry in the supply of news. The partisan composition of agency briefings reflects both outlets' decisions about which agencies to cover and agencies' subsequent selection from the resulting news supply. Because selection into an information channel can itself be informative (Boehmke et al., 2006), I examine these processes separately. To test whether partisan news sources publish more articles relevant to agencies with similar ideological slants, I identify a set of potentially relevant news for each agency and calculate the proportion of news from right-leaning sources.

To estimate the relevant supply of news for each agency, I searched for each agency's



(a) How articles are selected for news briefings.

(b) Method of identifying subset of potentially relevant news using agency names as keywords.

Figure 2: Diagram of agency news selection.

name, limiting the results to news outlets cited in the briefings. Recall that the briefings are the result of a multi-step filtering process. As shown in Figure 2a, there are three primary steps: (1) collect all published articles, (2) identify a set of potentially relevant articles using keywords, and (3) use human employees to select articles for the news briefings.

While I could not identify all keyword queries used to define potentially relevant articles, the agency name is almost certainly one of these keywords. During the contract solicitation process, the DHS told contractors, "[w]e suggest including all component names and their jurisdiction as keywords to start" (Department of Homeland Security, 2018, p. 8). Figure 2 visualizes how articles with agency names are a subset of potentially relevant news articles.

To determine the set of articles that mention agencies, I queried Media Cloud for articles that contain each agency's name and then subset the Media Cloud results to domestic news sources cited in the briefings. I excluded articles from Media Cloud if (a) the source domain never appeared in a briefing, (b) it came from a general interest local source or government website, or (c) it came from an international source, which includes sources based outside the U.S. or primarily covering other countries. Major wire services (AP, Reuters, UPI) were not counted as international sources. Because other countries have similarly named agencies, a large number of articles from international sources were not relevant to U.S. agencies.

To determine how well the agency name keywords capture the full set of potentially-

relevant articles, I scraped thousands of randomly sampled article URLs from the DHS, USCIS, and VA briefings. For the VA and most of the DHS subagencies, the agency's name can be found in 50-93% of the briefing articles. Only 24% of the articles in the FEMA section mention FEMA by name. Overall, 29% of the DHS briefing articles mention "Homeland Security," and 49% mention DHS or one of the DHS subagencies by name. USCIS is a clear outlier. 21% of the articles in the USCIS section of the DHS briefing mention USCIS by name, but only 8% of the articles in the separate USCIS briefing mention it by name. For more details, see Appendix A.6.

Additionally, I tested whether an expanded query list would change my results. The Small Business Administration (2022) contract documents contained a draft list of keywords. The list includes combinations of the agency acronym and other terms, including agency leader names and distinctive subcomponent and program names. Using combinations of agency policy areas, abbreviations, leaders, and subcomponent names, I generated 3,001 additional queries (see Appendix A.10 for details). While the expanded queries did produce more articles, the original name-only queries returned 71% of the article URLs in the expanded sample. Using the expanded query dataset does not substantively change the results (see Appendix A.10).

Figure 3 plots the partisan composition of the news supply. To produce Figure 3, I queried Media Cloud for articles that mention each agency during the time periods covered by the briefings (for details, see Appendix A.3). For each agency, I then calculate the proportion of articles from right-leaning sources. The regression line shows the relationship between agency ideology and the amount of coverage an agency receives from right-leaning news outlets. "DHS" only includes articles about "Homeland Security." "DHS (+subagencies)" also includes articles that contain one of the DHS subagency names.

If the conservative news sources preferentially cover conservative agencies or center/liberal sources preferentially cover liberal agencies, we will see a positive coefficient. Consistent with this supply-side explanation, Figure 3 reveals a strong positive relationship

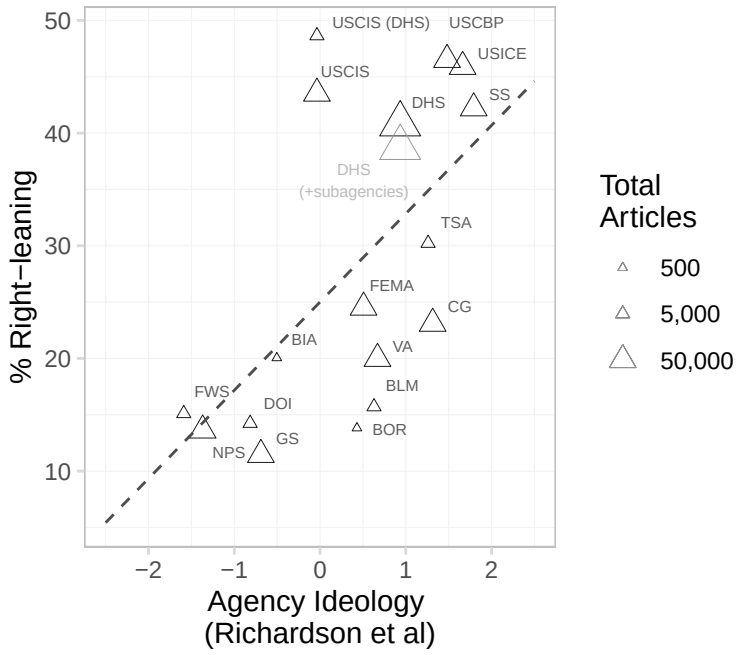


Figure 3: Supply of partisan news about government agencies. Based on Media Cloud queries for agency names during time periods covered by briefings. The best fit line excludes 'DHS (+subagencies).'

between agency ideology and the production of news ($\beta = 0.078$). Specifically, partisan news sources are more likely to publish news about ideologically-aligned agencies.

Because Media Cloud does not monitor all sources in the briefings, Figure 3 is not directly comparable to Figure 1. To compare the supply-side disparity to the briefings, I recalculate the regression line from Figure 1 after dropping domains that are not collected by Media Cloud ($\beta = 0.074$). The slopes are similar across measures: for a one-unit change in agency ideology, right-leaning outlets produce about 7.8 percentage points more coverage mentioning the agency by name and compose roughly 7.4 percentage points more of its news briefing.

Is there evidence of preferential selection after controlling for the supply of news?

While the results in Figure 3 show that a supply asymmetry could explain the relationship in Figure 1, the analysis is not conclusive. To formally test whether there is any evidence of selection bias conditional on an article being published, I directly compared the briefings to potentially relevant articles published during the same period.

Referring back to Figure 2b, I collect the set of articles mentioning an agency's name (Region B) and determine which articles were included in the news briefings (Region C). I then determine whether the included articles (Region C) are more likely to be from right-leaning news sources, compared to the other potentially relevant articles (Region B).

For Figure 4, I match the Media Cloud dataset to the briefing data using the article URLs. The resulting 'matched sample' contains all published articles that mention each agency name and an outcome variable that is 1 if the article is matched to the briefings and 0 otherwise. I searched for a match across the entire briefing, not just the subsection dedicated to an agency. Because URLs are unavailable for the DOI briefings, I also matched the datasets using the article publication date and domain (see Appendix A.5). Both matching procedures yield similar results across all robustness checks (see Appendix A.7; see also Appendix A.10.6).

Before testing for preferential selection, I examined whether articles about agencies are similar to the other articles in the briefings and found a key difference. The association between agency ideology and media slant is stronger for the subset of articles with agency names. There is a positive but weaker association among briefing articles without agency names (see Appendix A.6). I get similar results when I use the expanded set of agency-related queries (see Appendix A.10). Without the full set of keywords used to identify the set of potentially relevant articles in Figure 2a, I cannot test for preferential selection among articles that do not contain agency names or the expanded agency queries. However, the partisan skew documented in Figure 1 is less pronounced among these articles. Therefore, the selection analysis below applies to the subset of briefing articles for which the association between agency ideology and media slant is strongest.

Formally, to test whether the slant of an outlet still affects its inclusion after accounting for supply, I use the following model: $Incl_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{Right}_i + \beta_2 \text{Center}_i + \beta_3 I_i + \beta_4 (\text{Right}_i \times I_i) + \beta_5 (\text{Center}_i \times I_i) + \epsilon$. For each article i, $Incl_i$ is 1 if the article is included in the briefing, Right_i and Center_i are indicators for Right-leaning and Center slant, and I_i is the ideology of the agency mentioned in the article. If agencies are preferentially selecting articles from

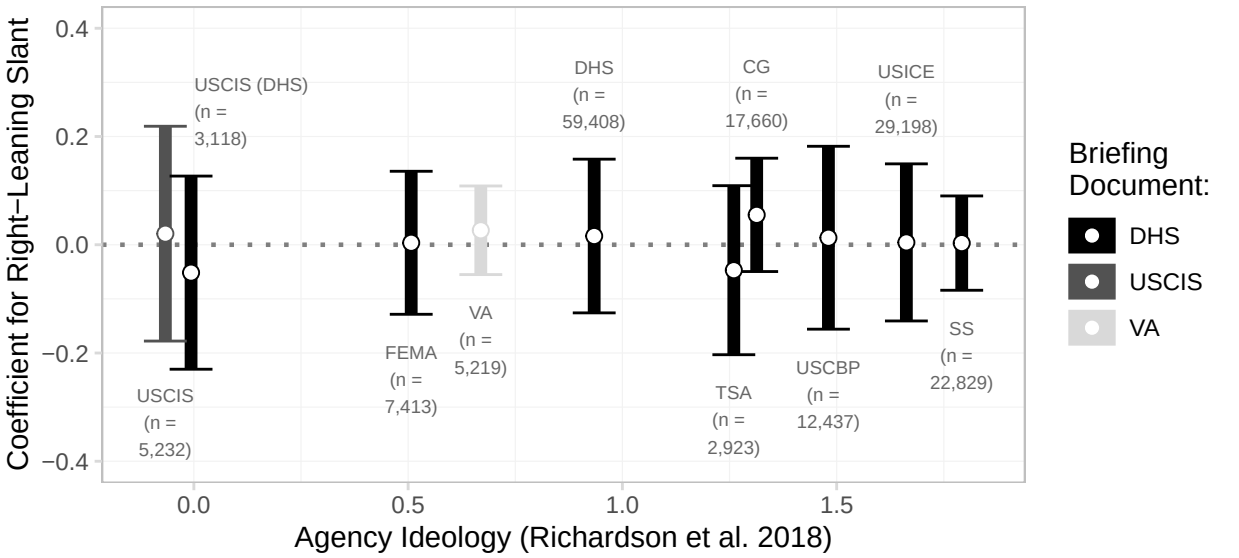


Figure 4: Estimated effect of right-leaning slant on the probability that an article is included in the news briefing. 95% confidence intervals. Models use OLS with robust standard errors clustered by news source and article URL. Outcome variable is binary indicator (1 if article included in news briefing, 0 otherwise). Independent variable is media slant; left-leaning sources are the reference category.

ideologically-aligned sources, the interaction between agency ideology and right-leaning slant would be positive (β_4). In contrast, the results suggest a weak, possibly negative relationship. To test the robustness, I ran the regression with varying samples, matching methods, slant measures, and ideology measures. Across specifications, the interaction estimates are small and mostly negative (see Figures A25 and A23).

This null finding is evident in Figure 4. Instead of an interaction, I run a separate regression for each agency, $Incl_i = \beta_0 + \beta_R \text{Right}_i + \beta_C \text{Center}_i + \epsilon$, and plot the coefficient for right-leaning news sources (β_R). A positive coefficient indicates that the agency is more likely to include articles from right-leaning sources, compared to left-leaning sources. A negative estimate indicates the opposite, and a value near zero suggests it is equally likely to include articles from left- or right-leaning sources.

In Figure 4, I arrange the coefficients by agency ideology. If agencies preferentially selected co-partisan news sources, we would expect the point estimates to be higher for more conservative agencies. Figure 4 shows that the estimates do not follow this pattern, providing

no evidence of biased selection. In fact, most of the estimates are close to zero.

When the results are matched by publication date and source, the estimates are similar, although they are slightly lower, likely because most large news sources are center-left and this method tends to overestimate matches among the most-cited sources (see Figure A26). Nevertheless, this alternate matching method also shows no relationship between agency ideology and the coefficients, including for DOI and its subagencies.

Collectively, the results yield three key findings. First, there is a strong association between an agency's ideology and the extent to which it cites partisan news sources. Second, the same association appears in the supply of news about agencies. Third, conditional on publication of news about an agency, there is no evidence that liberal or conservative agencies prefer news from ideologically-aligned sources.

4.2. Asymmetric production of news about agencies

To assess whether the supply-side asymmetry extends beyond the briefing sample, I expand the analysis to a broader set of agencies and time periods. Because the briefings cover different time periods and a limited number of agencies, Figure 3 alone cannot establish that the supply-side asymmetry extends beyond the agencies and periods represented in the briefing sample. To test whether a supply asymmetry exists over the entire period, I queried Media Cloud for all 165 agencies categorized in Richardson et al. (2018) over 85 randomly sampled weeks from January 2015 through May 2025.[6] In Figure 5, I plot the proportion of articles from right-leaning sources.

Figure 5 reveals that there is a durable asymmetry in the supply of news and that it extends beyond the 16 agencies in the briefing sample. To calculate the standard error of the regression line in Figure 5, I clustered the standard errors by agency, news source, and article URL. The data include 1,215,265 article-agency pairs, 919,329 unique URLs, 165 agencies, and 337 sources. Figure 5 confirms a statistically-significant, positive relationship

[6]The weeks were selected using stratified random sampling and 6-month strata. An extra week was sampled from April 2025; removing it does not affect the results.

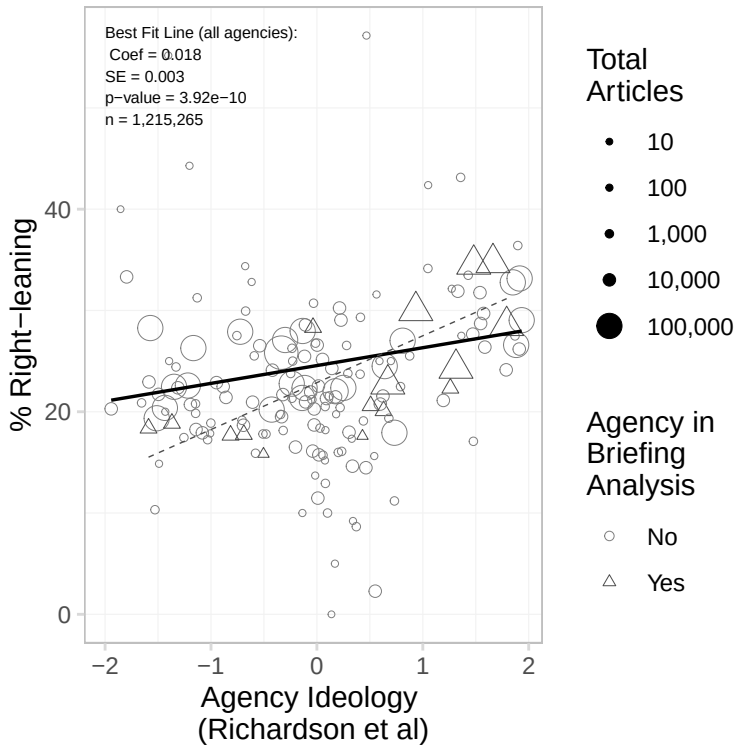


Figure 5: Supply of partisan news about government agencies. Includes articles that mention agencies with ideology scores during 85 randomly sampled weeks from 2015-2025. Standard errors calculated using heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors and clustering by agency, news source, and article URL.

between an agency's ideology and the amount of coverage it receives from right-leaning news sources. Compared to the most liberal agencies, the most conservative agencies receive approximately 8 percentage points more news from right-leaning media sources (β=0.018, se=0.003, p=3.92e-10, n=1,215,265). In Appendix A.4, I examine outlet-level heterogeneity, showing that left-leaning outlets generally produce more coverage of liberal agencies and right-leaning outlets generally produce more coverage of conservative agencies.

Comparing the briefing agencies to the full set of agencies shows that the supply-side relationship is stronger in the briefing sample than across agencies more broadly. In Figure 5, the solid line is the best fit line for all agencies and the dotted line is the best fit line for the briefing agencies (β=0.046, se=0.004, p=2.54e-08, n=172,175). Nevertheless, even if the 16 briefing agencies were removed from Figure 5, there would still be a statistically-significant, positive relationship between agency ideology and media slant. Moreover, this relationship

is strikingly robust. The results replicate when I use an alternate media database (GDELT) and other measures of partisan slant and agency ideology (see Appendix A.4).

4.3. Limits of a Supply-Side Explanation

While the asymmetric supply of news can explain the aggregate relationship between agency ideology and briefing slant, this does not imply that preferential selection never occurs. First, the supply and selection analyses are limited to articles that contain an agency's name or other agency-related search terms. I cannot assess selection among articles that do not contain these terms. Second, the previous findings do not rule out preferential selection under all conditions. Rather, the evidence shows that the disparity in the supply of news about agencies is sufficient to explain the association in Figure 1; there is no evidence of preferential selection in Figure 4; and the supply-side asymmetry is not an artifact of the time periods and agencies in the briefing sample.

The prior tests examine aggregate patterns across agencies, which may obscure changes in selection over time. Presidential transitions provide one opportunity to examine such changes because they alter agency personnel and priorities, and political appointees have input into contracting decisions (Bolton et al., 2021; Spenkuch et al., 2023). Because presidential transitions could alter the value of individual sources as well as the supply of news, these comparisons cannot identify the cause of any change in selection. However, transitions are useful for considering the limits of a supply-side explanation.

Evidence of changes across presidential administrations is mixed. The proportion of conservative coverage in the DOI briefings remains relatively stable before and after the 2017 transition from Barack Obama to Donald Trump (see Figure A27). The VA briefings provide a weaker test because the series ends about a month after Joe Biden's inauguration, but they also show little change. By contrast, DHS and USCIS briefings each changed shortly after Trump took office in January 2025, but the changes were not identical.

In late March 2025, DHS briefings began to incorporate much more right-leaning coverage

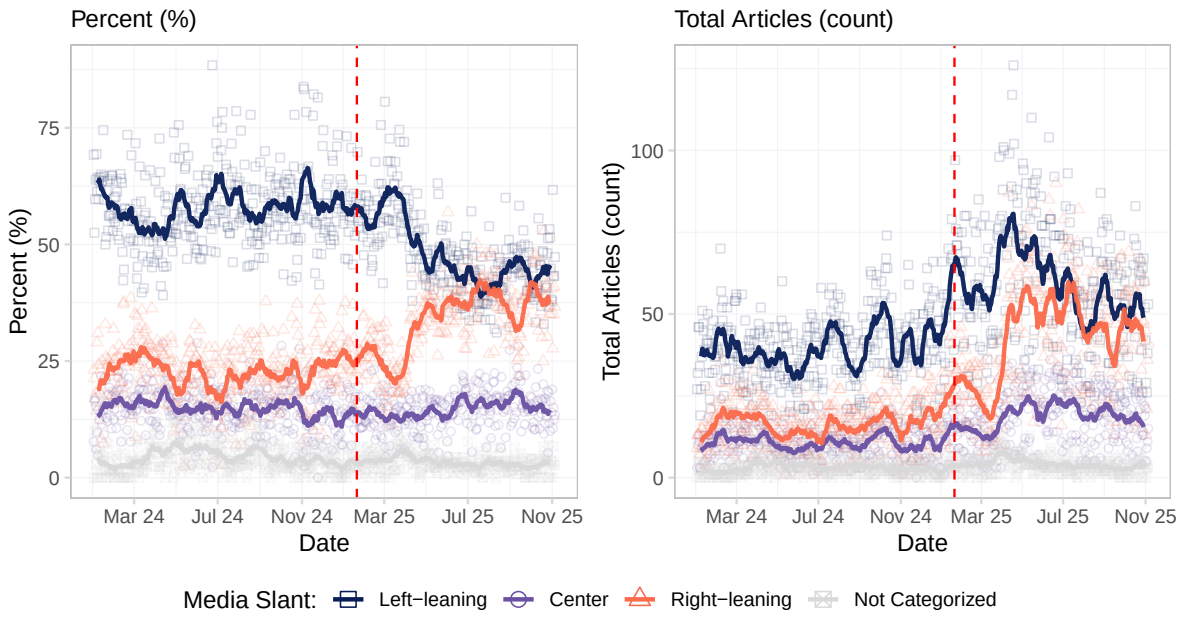


Figure 6: Over-time partisan composition of the DHS news briefings. Dotted line at Trump's 2025 inauguration. Lines are 2-week rolling averages.

(see Figure 6). This rightward shift is robust to different measures of media slant (see Figures A29 and A30) and the inclusion of local general interest sources and government websites (see Figure A28).

The sources added to the DHS briefings provide additional evidence that the shift cannot be explained by changes in news supply alone. Before March 2025, the DHS news briefings never cited certain far-right news sources, including Breitbart, Newsmax, the Blaze, the Daily Wire, the Daily Caller, the Daily Signal, and the Federalist. Since April, all of these sources have been featured prominently. Two of these sources—Breitbart and Newsmax—are among the ten most frequently cited sources after April despite never appearing before March. The addition of these sources cannot be attributed solely to the news supply. Relevant coverage from these right-leaning sources was available before the shift,[7] and the contractor had collected these sources in the past.[8]

[7]Using Media Cloud and the source websites, I verified that each of the 31 right-leaning sources added after April existed and produced coverage about DHS before 2025.

[8]TechMIS had previously included some of these outlets, including Breitbart, in its 2022-2023 USCIS briefings.

USCIS, which is housed within DHS and also uses TechMIS, exhibits a related but less pronounced change. Beginning in April 2025, its briefings increasingly cite conservative sources including Breitbart, Newsmax, the Blaze, the Daily Wire, the Federalist, OAN, and the Daily Signal, but unlike DHS, these sources remain relatively infrequent and contribute less to the aggregate balance of coverage. In both the USCIS and DHS briefings, there is a distinct increase in newly added ideologically-extreme sources in April and May 2025 (Figure A34). In contrast, there is no equivalent spike in DOI or VA briefings.

Overall, these results suggest that selection can change after presidential transitions, but additional work is needed to determine the degree of preferential selection and to isolate when selection will occur.

5. Discussion

This paper examines how federal agencies collect information from the news and the consequences of these efforts. Drawing on government contracts and internal documents, I first characterize the motives and processes underlying agency news collection. Consistent with their motives, the results suggest that agencies as a whole do not systematically prefer ideologically aligned news outlets. However, these findings raise important questions about the consequences of an asymmetric news supply and how agencies should approach news collection. While less conclusive, recent changes to the DHS briefing suggest that incentives for comprehensive news collection do not prevent preferential selection under some conditions.

Importantly, this paper reveals that asymmetries in the supply of news are reflected in agency news exposure. To fully understand the consequences of asymmetric coverage, additional research will be needed on its origins and implications. Nevertheless, prior research on government decision making and partisan media suggests that the asymmetries in Figures 1, 3, and 5 have important political and policy consequences. Examining this research also suggests directions for future research and provides insight into the normative implications

of an asymmetric information supply.

Information about the existence of policy problems and demand for policy change has been shown to affect policy decisions and elite strategy. Collectively, this research suggests that differences in news content can affect policymaking when they affect judgment about public opinion or the existence, severity, and solutions to policy problems. The only previous study of government news summaries (Karpowitz, 2009) used Richard Nixon's handwritten notes to connect information in the White House news briefings to Nixon's communications efforts, policy-making activity, personnel management, and emotional state. Studies have also linked news exposure to important judgments about public opinion (Broockman & Skovron, 2018; Furnas & LaPira, 2024), the existence of policy problems (Baumgartner & Jones, 2015), the importance of policy problems (Van Aelst & Walgrave, 2016; Walgrave & Van Aelst, 2006), the best solutions to policy problems (Jablonski & Seim, 2024), and the activities of other political actors (Cook, 1998). Beyond studies of media, information has been shown to affect elite decision making and responsiveness (Jablonski & Seim, 2024; Liaqat, 2019; Seim et al., 2020).

Turning to prior research on partisan media bias, existing research has established that the partisan slant of a source shapes the information content of news by affecting story selection and presentation (Broockman & Kalla, 2025; Groeling, 2013; Grossman et al., 2022; Hosseinmardi et al., 2025; Larcinese et al., 2011; Mullainathan & Shleifer, 2005; Puglisi, 2011; Puglisi & Snyder Jr, 2011; Shultziner & Stukalin, 2021). This evidence is further bolstered by the results of this paper. The asymmetric supply of news shown in Figure 5 illustrates how right-leaning news sources produce more coverage of conservative agencies and less coverage of liberal agencies.

Future research should investigate the causes and consequences of the partisan asymmetry found in Figure 5. Compared to the dangers of asymmetric supply, more attention has been paid to the dangers of preferential news selection (e.g. Broockman & Kalla, 2025). Nevertheless, an asymmetric supply of news also raises concerns, particularly in the context

of elite news consumption and given the size of the disparity. Some liberal agencies collect almost no coverage from conservative sources. If bureaucrats believe that the briefing collection process is unbiased, they may be less likely to recognize supply-driven limitations to their information environment. Being aware of bias has been shown to mitigate the effects of bias (Lee, 2017). An incomplete information supply could increase the chances that the agency makes a strategic error, but it could also affect agency behavior in less visible ways, like forcing an agency to expend more resources on other types of information collection efforts. Unless they explicitly seek out conservative voices from other sources, liberal agencies will have less information about the actors, issues, and narratives emphasized by conservative media. Supply-driven omissions are particularly insidious because both recipients and overseers may fail to recognize missing information, and accountability is particularly difficult when consequential actions or omissions are difficult to observe (e.g. Gailmard & Patty, 2019).

Interestingly, outside of a few sectors like emergency communication, there has been limited prior research on how political elites should optimize media monitoring. The lack of clear guidance may explain why very few media monitoring contracts contain specific provisions for ensuring the balance of agency news briefings. Only one contract contains quotas or other provisions for ensuring source diversity, and its quotas apply to the geographic diversity of local news coverage (Consumer Product Safety Commission, 2020). None of the contracts require that contractors monitor an ideologically-diverse set of sources. Arguably, agencies should oversample underrepresented types of news. However, political sensitivities around news bias may limit agency staff or the monitoring service itself from adopting more complex optimization strategies and instead favor basic heuristics like selecting news equally or in proportion to the news supply.

Especially in the age of large language models and other technological advancements, future research should consider how to design government media monitoring strategies that efficiently capture valuable information in news and inform staff about the limitations of

news collection. Doing so will require further examination of why the news supply is skewed, what processes produce these asymmetries, and how they translate into substantive informational differences. This will require examining story content, including topics, frames, and narratives within sources.

As expected, the complex motives behind agency news consumption discourage agencies from preferentially seeking out co-partisan news; however, under some circumstances, the preferences of powerful individuals within an agency can shape the selection process. Figure 6 reveals that the composition of DHS news briefings changed dramatically after Donald Trump returned to office. Under Kristi Noem's leadership, coverage from far-right news sources has increased in volume and prominence. While Figure 6 shows a dramatic and persistent change, the briefings alone cannot conclusively identify the cause of this change. There are several possible explanations, some of which are consistent with the agency's overall preferences while others require that the priorities of agency leadership dominate other motives for news collection.

First, the new administration could make different judgments about the value of news to the agency as a whole. Not all sources are created equally. In order to create a quickly digestible and representative picture of the news, agencies might choose to prioritize information based on factors like source popularity, influence, or accuracy. Agencies may also choose to exclude low-value information when the cost of including it is too high. Agencies may choose to remove particularly offensive or false information from a document circulated widely within an agency. Given the DOJ's decision to fire TechMIS over an antisemitic blog (Barrett, 2019), contractors themselves may adjust content to avoid controversy or termination. Individual judgments of value or cost are influenced by personal attributes like partisan affiliation (Bhuiyan et al., 2020; Ladd & Podkul, 2018) as well as the broader political environment. For example, it may be particularly valuable to have sources monitored by the president, even if they contain offensive or false information.

Alternatively, political leaders may impose their own preferences on the briefings, at the

expense of other constituencies within the agency. Most obviously, agency leadership may see these briefings as an opportunity to advance a political agenda by shaping the information environment of other leadership and staff. Because the news briefings are distributed widely to other staff and leadership, they are not only a channel for principals to collect news from outside sources. Briefings are also a means for principals to control the information provided to their agents and, potentially, signal their preferences, priorities, or political control of the agency to staff. The EPA's dispute with Bulletin Intelligence during the first Trump administration suggests that leaders might also seek to insulate themselves and their employees from negative coverage (Benton, 2017; Choma & Leber, 2019; Dravis et al., 2017; Ericksen, 2017a; Leber et al., 2017).

While there are strategic reasons for restricting or expanding collection of extreme or low-quality news, the changes at DHS raise concerns. At a critical time in U.S. immigration policy, the prominence of relatively extreme conservative news sources may both reflect and reinforce the administration's priorities. Recent changes to news briefings reflect a broader pattern of politicizing information and manipulating access to media coverage. For decades, the government's extensive efforts to collect, curate, and distribute news drew little outside notice. That changed in recent years when these once-routine practices came under heightened political scrutiny.

In the early months of his second administration, President Donald J. Trump and his team devoted significant attention to government news consumption and payments for news services, going so far as to cancel widely used services from Politico and other news service providers. In addition to targeting Politico, Trump's administration has also explored cancelling other center- and left-leaning news subscriptions (Basu & Caputo, 2025; Guardian Staff, 2025) and taken steps to limit access to news at the Social Security agency (Sheffey, 2025). These decisions were not merely symbolic; they actively obstructed and politicized the supply of information flowing to government agencies.

In fact, by December 2025, the Trump administration began to quietly reverse its decision

to cancel key media contracts. Agencies "raised concerns about losing information when the White House initially requested cancellations," and the White House itself remarked that "unfortunately we are forced to read the Fake News so we know what lies we have to debunk" (Kornfield et al., 2025). This episode highlights a central dynamic explored in this paper. While political leaders may desire to alter bureaucratic information collection, their continued need for the information that news provides may constrain those efforts.

Together, the findings of this paper show that even if agencies do not select ideologically-aligned news, they operate within an information environment shaped by substantial partisan asymmetries in the supply of coverage. Additionally, under certain circumstances, choices by agency leadership may also alter the balance of information available to government staff. These results underscore the need for continued research on information collection within bureaucracies, optimal strategies for news collection, and how informational disparities affect their decision making. Future work should also examine whether similar dynamics appear in other institutional contexts like Congress and the White House, and which institutional conditions make information acquisition more susceptible to political control.

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